



## MEDALS AND MILESTONES: TAMIL NADU'S SPORTING LEGACY IN 2024

### SPRINGBOARDING ATHLETES TO GLORY

The Government of Tamil Nadu has made remarkable strides in supporting and nurturing talented athletes who aspire to excel on both national and international stages. By hosting a variety of high-profile national and international sporting events, the state not only provides a platform for these athletes to showcase their skills but also enhances the region's visibility in the sports arena.

In addition to organising events, the government actively promotes the welfare of sportspersons through various initiatives aimed at fostering their development. This includes providing high cash incentives, state-of-the-art training facilities, and financial aid through the Tamil Nadu Champions Foundation. Such measures enable athletes to chase their dreams and strive for excellence in sports. Through these efforts, Tamil Nadu is committed to creating an environment where deserving sportspersons can thrive and realize their full potential.



D. Gukesh is supported by the Sports Development Authority of Tamil Nadu (SDAT) through its ELITE Sportsperson scheme, which provides him with annual financial assistance up to ₹30 lakh. Additionally, following his achievement as the World Chess Champion, he received a high cash incentive of ₹5 crore from the Government of Tamil Nadu.

### CATAPULTING PARA ATHLETES

Tamil Nadu has a long-standing reputation for its progressive initiatives aimed at improving accessibility and empowering the differently abled. In a significant move, the state organized the Tamil Nadu Chief Minister's Trophy Games 2024, which featured dedicated sports events tailored specifically for differently abled athletes. These events encompassed a variety of disciplines, including Athletics, Standing Badminton, Wheelchair Table Tennis, Adapted Volleyball, Throwball, Kabaddi, and Football. Each of these sports was meticulously adapted to ensure inclusivity, allowing athletes to showcase their skills and compete in a supportive environment.

Moreover, nearly 600 athletes have benefited from the Tamil Nadu Champions Foundation, with almost half of them being para-athletes. In a pathbreaking initiative for the country, Tamil Nadu is establishing Para Sports Arenas at six locations across the state.

These efforts have yielded impressive results, as four para-athletes from Tamil Nadu—Mariyappan Thangavelu, Manisha Ramadass, Thulasimathi Murugesan, and Nithya Sre Sumathy Sivan—achieved remarkable success at the Paris Paralympics 2024, bringing laurels to both the state and the country.

In a significant milestone for Tamil Nadu, the state has achieved remarkable recognition at the National Sports Awards 2024. For the first time in its history, five sportspersons have been honoured in a single year, with four receiving the prestigious Arjuna Awards and one being awarded the Major Dhyan Chand Khel Ratna Award – the highest sporting honour of the country.



This was evident in the way Government of Tamil Nadu had organised the Chennai Chess Grandmasters 2023 which took place from 15 to 21 December 2023. This prestigious tournament was particularly significant as it served as a launching pad for the rising chess star, D. Gukesh. His impressive performance during the event earned him a spot in the FIDE Candidates Tournament, a key competition that was held in Canada in February 2024. Gukesh's talent shone through in the Candidates Tournament, where he successfully secured his qualification for the highly esteemed World Chess Championship, which took place in Singapore. His remarkable journey culminated in an extraordinary victory at the championship, where he not only triumphed over the seasoned Ding Liren but also became the youngest player ever to win the title.